

Algorithmic Agonism: Automating Resistance in Public Space through AI-Driven Digital Calligraffiti

1. Context & Motivation

As a Palestinian artist and the founder of an AI-automation startup (The 24/7), my practice sits at the friction point between ancient tradition (Arabic Calligraphy) and emergent technology (Generative AI). Currently, AI models are predominantly trained on Western datasets, often resulting in the "digital erasure" or misrepresentation of marginalized narratives. When I attempt to generate images of Palestinian resistance or specific Arabic poetic structures using standard commercial models (like Midjourney or DALL-E), the results are often sanitized, orientalized, or censored.

This project proposes a radical shift: instead of viewing AI merely as a tool for image generation, I propose to treat it as an autonomous collaborator in "Authorized Resistance." By training a custom AI agent on a curated dataset of Palestinian poetry (Ghassan Zaqtan) and my own calligraphic gestures, I aim to develop a "Counter-Algorithm" capable of reclaiming public space.

2. Research Question

How can custom-trained Generative AI agents serve as autonomous collaborators in decolonial public art practices? Specifically, can an AI-driven projection system (Infl3ctor 2.0) "read" the architecture of European hegemony and "write" counter-narratives in real-time, effectively automating the act of artistic resistance?

3. Methodology & Artistic Process

My research follows a practice-based methodology structured around three iterative Work Packages (WPs). It leverages my position as the co-developer of the Infl3ctor technology (in collaboration with media artist Michael Ang) to conduct a deep technical and artistic intervention. The goal is to evolve the Infl3ctor from a passive transmission device into an active, generative AI agent.

WP1: The Counter-Archive (Data Sovereignty)

Standard generative models (like Midjourney or DALL-E) are trained on indiscriminate, often Western-centric datasets that tend to "orientalize" or censor Palestinian narratives. To reclaim agency, I will build a sovereign dataset:

Textual Data: I will fine-tune a Small Language Model (SLM) on the complete poetic corpus of Ghassan Zaqtan, focusing on themes of memory, distinct Palestinian topography, and the "unauthorized" narrative.

Visual Data: I will train LoRA (Low-Rank Adaptation) adapters on my own 15-year archive of calligraphic gestures and Digital Calligraffiti tags.

Objective: To create a "Palestinian Model" that understands the nuances of Arabic script and the political weight of specific poetic metaphors, ensuring the AI generates culturally accurate and politically charged content.

WP2: Infl3ctor 2.0 (The Agentic Upgrade)

Currently, the Infl3ctor utilizes computer vision to digitize analog hand movements in real-time. This phase aims to introduce "Agentic Behavior" to the hardware:

Context Awareness: I will integrate a vision-language model (VLM) that allows the Infl3ctor to "see" and analyze the projection surface (e.g., distinguishing a colonial monument from a modern glass facade).

Real-Time Generation: Instead of solely mirroring my hand, the system will be programmed to function in "Autopilot Mode." It will analyze the urban context and autonomously generate calligraphic interventions that respond to the architecture.

The Shift: This transforms the tool from a brush into a partner, capable of improvising visual text based on the trained counter-archive.

WP3: Performance as Inquiry (Human-Machine Agonism)

The final phase involves a series of public interventions (in Bergen and Amman) staged as "Duets" between myself and the AI Agent.

The Experiment: I will initiate a calligraphic line, and the AI agent will be tasked to complete it, contradict it, or expand upon it based on its training.

The Agonism: I will investigate moments of friction: Does the AI, unbound by human social fear, suggest more radical or "illegal" interventions than I would? Does it hallucinate new forms of resistance?

Outcome: These ephemeral projections will be documented to analyze the potential of AI as a co-author in decolonial activism.

4. Relevance to the Call (AI in Artistic Processes)

This project goes beyond using AI as a "style filter." It integrates AI into the core process of artistic creation and intervention. It utilizes my dual expertise as a visual artist and a tech founder to interrogate the politics of code. By building my own datasets and workflows (drawing on my experience with The 24/7), I ensure that the "Black Box" of AI is opened and decolonized.